AN UPPER CUT

PREETI PAWAR, 22

Sport: ***BOXING***

Discipline
54kg (Bantamweight)

Claim to fame
Gold at 2026 Asian Championships, Commonwealth Games, 2025 World Boxing Cup



Each time she walks out for a fight, Preeti Pawar's mind is in overdrive—she sizes up the opposition and visualises tactics. What the crowd sees is a boxer flashing the biggest smile in the arena. "I know my family and friends are watching. It's all for them," she laughs. Once in the ring, a calm determination takes over. With speed as her forte, the southpaw shuffles around with grace, finding the right opportunity to land clinical blows, before weaving out of harm's way. Pawar's latest triumph was gold at the Commonwealth Games, a relatively easy outing in terms of the opposition, but the Asian Championships in April presented a formidable challenge. Pawar accounted for 2024 Olympic bronze medallist, South Korea's Im Ae-ji, and three-time world champion, Chinese Taipei's Huang Hsiao-wen. "Beating Im was good for my confidence. These are boxers I would meet at the Asian Games, so I had to give my best to understand things that need work," says the JSW athlete.

The focus currently has been on landing body shots and her footwork. Strength and endurance have been a work in progress since recovering from hepatitis, which hurt her 2024 Paris Olympics campaign and resulted in a long break. "I had doubts if I would compete at the top again. That phase made me strong mentally," she recalls. Her first big test after recovery was at the World Cup in November 2025, where she beat Huang and Italy's Sirine Charaabi, bronze medallist at the World Championships, en route to gold.

At the national camp in Patiala, she considers Poonam and Aarti Dhariyal to be strong sparring partners, besides CWG medallists Sakshi Chaudhary and Priya Ghanghas. "There's desire to do better than the other. It pushes us hard," she says. ■

—Shail Desai